The Chrome OS equivalent to the Start Menu, which is just a web page with glorified hyperlinks

Working on Chrome

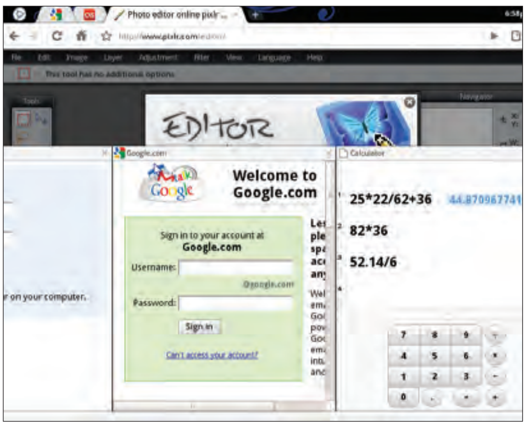
Once you login, you get a start menu which is basically an array of different web sites. Conventional web services are treated as applications in Chrome. Gmail is an application at par with Google Docs, a radio streaming service and a flash chess game on a web site. Basically every tab you open on a web browser is no longer considered as a "page" within Chrome OS, and instead is a "window". There is no desktop to speak of, as everything is within the Chrome browser window. The equivalent device for shortcuts or icons are compressed tabs that are always on irrespective of what you are doing. Some applications like the Lala streaming radio and GChat are given a unique treatment as "panels" that can be minimised when needed. These are always hovering along the bottom of the screen, to be called when needed. This new way of working may seem like it gives you no control, or freedom with your device, but this is not necessarily a bad thing.

You cannot install your own applications on Chrome as yet, as the root folders remain locked. A Linux OS with the Sudoers account disabled is about as secure as current technology is going to get, so no matter what happens, the operating system simply cannot get messed up. This means that the OS remains as fast and responsive as it was, even over prolonged use, as the underlying system is not changing at all. The flip side is that you will have to depend on the web for providing with all the applications that you need. There are some pretty neat web 2.0 applications out there, for everything from photo-editing to audio transcoding, but these are not as fast or as convinient as the desktop alternatives.

As soon as you plug in an external storage device, Chrome OS treats the folder structure as just another web page. You can click through the directories, and open up any file as long as there is something on the web that can read the file. As of now, this is not really a lot, the most exotic format that Chrome OS can handle is an MP3 file, which it opens in a player. Some of the more obscure, or even mundane items does need you to work backwards though. An .xml document will open in the browser itself, for example, but not with an editor web application. Chrome OS tries to make the concept of "downloading" old-fashioned, but does not really succeed at it.

Multimedia is a problem as of now, but between YouTube, Vimeo, Last.fm, Grooveshark, and the tons of other streaming options out there, this should not be much of an issue, by the time Chrome OS actually comes into circulation. Serious gaming is outright impossible, unless a dedicated hacker comes up with some elaborate mechanism (we are sure to see this), but the web is full of flash games for the casual gamer. Keep in mind the usage scenarios, and the kind of devices that Chrome OS is likely to show up on, and these are not really major disadvantages.

That said, there is not much to get excited about, unless you are already drooling over the Chrome browser, which would only be possible in a parallel universe without Firefox. The unbelievable start-up time is the single most impressive thing about Chrome OS. The browser as an OS model is great, but needs a lot more to offset the advantages of a traditional operating system – the ability to write out a document offline, for example.



Pinned applications (top left) and Panels in Chrome, minimisable and persistent windows

Life in the Clouds

Chrome OS is just a part of a larger trend. While a Cloud OS may be a little too premature for the entire planet, the general direction that Chrome OS is working towards, is more or less the future. The strict hold over formats and standards that companies enjoyed so far, belongs to an age that is passing by the day. Data intercompatibility and portability will be important for a lot of reasons, and we are likely to see stable, long lasting ways in which to create, store and share data. Open APIs that everyone can use are a part of this, which ensures that applications to use data and content can be designed by independent sources. Facebook and Twitter are shining examples of this trend at the moment. The way things are going, it would be relatively simple to drag and drop a photo from a mail attachment into your Facebook profile. While an OS based entirely on the cloud may not be an answer, a more hybridised approach, will not only work, but is already here to some extent. Adobe's Kuler for example, is a Web 2.0 swatch application that works with Adobe's Creative Suite 4 installed on the desktop. The lines between what is a web application and what is a desktop application has began to blur.

The biggest roadblock to this transformation is the internet itself. The world wide web sits on a network of wires almost three decades old now. These wires use hideously outdated protocols, and it is here, the back end of the web, that needs a major upgrade. The web was meant to be an academic endeavour, an agent for the sharing of information. It has grown to be much more, with the invasion of e-commerce, social networking, and now full fledged operating systems. The cloud right now really is wisps of data without any real support, The internet needs to be much more secure before users can move completely into the cloud. d